

ABHI HOME ®

THIRD-GENERATION INDIAN HOME TEXTILES · EST. 1965

Sourcing Home Textiles from India

*The buyer's guide to samples, lead times, MOQs,
incoterms, payment terms and documentation*

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ABOUT THIS GUIDE

What's inside

India produces a meaningful share of the world's home textile exports. The capability is deep, the certifications mature, the prices competitive. None of that is the hard part for a first-time buyer — **the hard part is operational**. This guide gives you the real calendar, the real flexibility, and the right questions to ask.

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Who wrote this

Abhijat Paliwal is the third-generation founder-leader of ABHI HOME®, a certified Indian home textile manufacturer and exporter established in 1965, supplying premium retailers across Europe, the Americas and Asia-Pacific — with a US trading entity for domestic invoicing.

SECTION 1

The sourcing calendar nobody tells you about

The order cycle from PO to DC delivery is typically **95–130 days**. Buyers underestimate this because they're calibrated against domestic suppliers (where 30 days is normal) or against China (where 75 days is typical). When a marketing team needs new bath mats on shelf in eight weeks, an India order isn't going to make it.

The other under-counted detail is the **multi-stage sample workflow**. Buyers used to a single sample round at home are surprised that Indian manufacturers run two or three sample stages by default — and skipping any of them creates problems at scale.

SECTION 2

The three sample stages, in order

1. Counter-sample (development sample)

The manufacturer's interpretation of your tech pack: construction, fabric base, weave, print position, embroidery placement, look-feel. Typically **10–14 days** for fabric-only development; **21 days** for fully made-up samples with finishing.

Expect to iterate — two to three counter-sample rounds are normal for a custom design. A perfect counter-sample on round one usually means existing stock is being pulled (your spec isn't actually being honoured), or you got lucky.

2. Lab dip (Pantone match)

Once construction is approved, the dye-house produces lab dips against your Pantone shades. Standard turnaround **5–7 days per round**; most programmes settle within two rounds. Difficult colours (very pale, very saturated, non-Pantone references) can take three or more.

Critical detail: evaluate lab dips under D65 daylight conditions — not warehouse lighting or a phone screen. Ask for a Pantone-Match-Confirmation document as the production “lock”.

3. Pre-production sample (PPS)

The make-or-break sample: produced on the same line, with the same operators, fabric lot and QC procedure as bulk. Standard turnaround **21 days** after lab-dip approval. Bulk should not start until PPS is signed off in writing.

Founder note

The single most common cause of buyer disappointment in Indian sourcing isn't price — it's the gap between sample quality and bulk quality. Ask explicitly: “Will my PPS run on the same line as the bulk order?” The answer should be yes.

SECTION 3

Production lead times: normal vs fast

From PO confirmation (after PPS approval) to FOB-Indian-port loading:

Construction type	Lead time
Standard cotton constructions — woven cushion covers, bath mats, kitchen linen, plain bedding	45–60 days
Jacquard, complex embroidery, hand-block printing, hand-tufted constructions	60–90 days
First-run programmes with significant fabric development, multi-step printing or new yarn sourcing	90–120 days

Repeat programmes (fabric, dye, print and construction already approved) run **25–35% faster** than first-run.

Speed-to-market tactics for urgent programmes

- **Pre-book fabric ahead of PPS approval.** Adds risk if PPS doesn't approve, but cuts 14–21 days.
- **Approve PPS in parallel with bulk start on a small risk slice** — for established relationships.
- **Air-freight a partial order** for floor-set timing. Costly, but rescues a missed retail window.

SECTION 4

Ocean transit windows by destination port

From the two main Indian export ports — Mundra (Gujarat, west coast) and Nhava Sheva / JNPT (near Mumbai) — typical 2026 transit windows:

Destination	Port	Days	Notes
UK	Felixstowe	22–28	Direct sailings on major lines
UK	Southampton, London Gateway	24–30	Same lanes; longer port rotation
Germany	Hamburg, Bremerhaven	25–32	Often via Mediterranean transshipment
Netherlands	Rotterdam	22–28	Major EU hub; inland barge onward
USA East	New York / Newark	28–34	Via Suez routing
USA East	Savannah	30–35	Popular for southeast distribution
USA West	Los Angeles / Long Beach	30–38	Via Singapore; Pacific routing
USA West	Oakland, Seattle	32–40	Fewer direct sailings
Australia	Sydney, Melbourne	25–32	Via Singapore
Japan	Tokyo, Yokohama	22–28	Direct sailings available
UAE	Jebel Ali	5–8	Short-haul; weekly sailings

- **Red Sea / Suez disruption** has added 10–14 days to traditional Suez routings in recent quarters.
- **Container availability tightens** in Indian peak export season (Aug–Oct); book 4–6 weeks ahead.

Rule of thumb: add **28 days ocean** to most major markets, plus **5–10 days** customs and inland.

SECTION 5

Total order-to-DC timelines

For a first-run programme to a UK or US distribution centre:

Stage	Duration
Counter-sample	10–14 days
Lab-dip rounds	5–14 days
Pre-production sample	21 days
Bulk production	45–90 days
Ocean transit	22–38 days
Customs + inland	5–10 days

Total: 110–180 days from initial brief to DC delivery. Repeat programmes compress to **75–100 days**.

Practical implication

If your retail window is AW September on-shelf, your PO needs confirmation by March. SS February on-shelf needs PO by August/September.

SECTION 6

MOQs: how flexible Indian manufacturers really are

- **Sampling-stage MOQs are very low** — manufacturers want to win the programme. Don't assume the sample MOQ is the production MOQ.
- **Production MOQs are economic-driven:** loom set-up, dye batch and printing screens each have minimum-economic runs below which unit cost rises sharply. A real OEM explains this commercially, not as a hard rule.
- **Mixed-design container programmes are the most flexible** — multiple SKUs per container amortise set-up across the order.
- **Pilot runs below typical MOQ are negotiable** for new buyer relationships, especially with a committed multi-season programme to follow.

The question to ask

"What's the lowest MOQ at which we can launch a viable programme without a per-unit cost premium?" A serious manufacturer will give a specific answer keyed to your construction.

SECTION 7

FOB, CIF, DAP, DDP — choosing your incoterm

FOB (Free On Board) Indian port

Manufacturer's responsibility ends when goods load at Mundra or Nhava Sheva. You arrange ocean freight, marine insurance, destination handling, customs, inland. **Use when** you have established freight forwarders and want control — best for multi-container volumes.

CIF (Cost, Insurance, Freight) destination port

Manufacturer arranges ocean freight and insurance to your port; you take over from there. **Use when** you lack a freight-forwarder relationship, or CIF pricing beats FOB-plus-your-freight. (CFR is the same minus insurance.)

DAP (Delivered At Place)

Door-to-door except import duty, which you pay. **Use for** variable-tariff scenarios where the manufacturer can't reasonably pre-pay duty.

DDP (Delivered Duty Paid) destination warehouse

Everything door-to-door including duty. Single landed-cost number, no operational overhead — most expensive, lowest friction. **Common for** smaller importers and D2C brands.

Incoterm	Buyer pays	Manufacturer pays	Best for
FOB	Ocean, insurance, customs, duty, inland	Up to ship loading	Established import operations
CIF	Customs, duty, inland	Ocean + insurance to dest. port	Mid-size buyers without freight team
DAP	Duty only	Door-to-door minus duty	Variable-tariff scenarios
DDP	Nothing	Everything door-to-door	Small importers, D2C brands

SECTION 8

Payment terms: standard vs risky

Standard structures for first-time buyer relationships:

- **30% advance / 70% against B/L** — common for well-known buyers; manufacturer takes some risk.
- **Letter of Credit at sight** — your bank guarantees payment on document presentation. Standard for new relationships from less familiar markets; adds bank fees.
- **LC 60/90-day usance** — an effective financing window. Common for retail buyers with predictable sell-through.
- **Open account 30/60/90 days** — reserved for established multi-year relationships.

Watch out for

- **100% advance** — rare and inappropriate for any reputable manufacturer. If demanded, walk away.
- **Above 50% advance for production volume** is unusual (50% can be normal for very small pilots or highly customised development).
- **Avalised drafts and SBLCs** add complexity and cost — useful in specific situations, usually overkill.

SECTION 9

The shipment documentation pack

Every shipment from a competent Indian manufacturer should include:

- Commercial invoice — HS classification, country of origin, currency, terms
- Packing list with carton-level breakdown
- Bill of Lading (B/L) issued by the shipping line
- Certificate of Origin — REX form for EU, GSP where applicable, for preferential duty
- OEKO-TEX, GOTS, GRS certificates and Transaction Certificates as applicable to the SKUs
- Lab test reports matching retailer compliance — CPSIA, REACH, Prop 65 etc.
- Sedex SMETA audit report for facility-level social compliance
- Care label and country-of-origin label artwork
- Insurance certificate (CIF/DDP) or buyer's insurance copy (FOB)

Pro tip

Define this documentation pack in the PO terms, not in a side conversation. Specify what's sent ahead of B/L, what travels with the shipment, and what's emailed at clearance.

Bottom line

Indian home textile sourcing is operationally deeper than first-time buyers anticipate — but the depth comes with reliability once you understand the calendar. Build in **110–180 days** for first-run programmes, **75–100 days** for repeats, lock the documentation pack in the PO, and pick the incoterm that matches your operational sophistication — not the lowest line item on a cold quote.

Ready to start sourcing?

Tell us about your programme — product category, target volumes, retail price band, sustainability requirements — and we'll come back within 48 hours with feasibility, indicative pricing and the certification scope that fits.

www.abhihome.in/contact.html · info@abhihome.in

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